Dying roses

By

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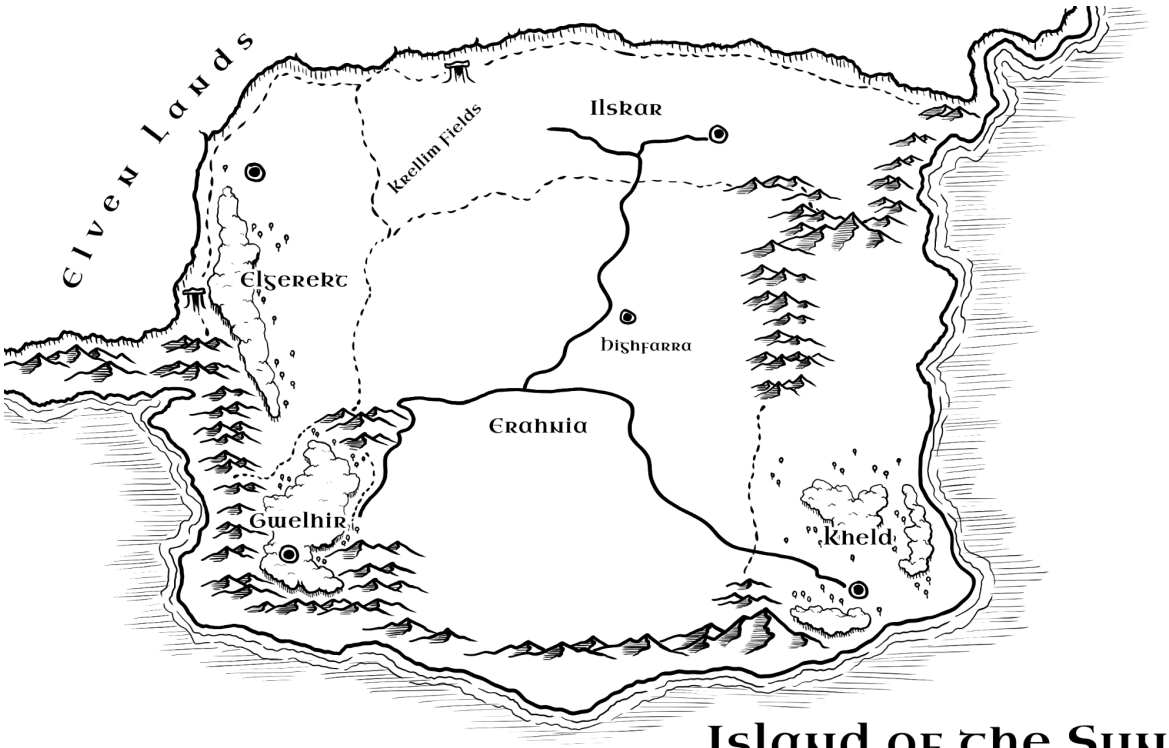

Island of the Sun

The end of peace

King Begrim slumped in his saddle after the long ride, making his way through the crowded camp. The atmosphere was thick with the smells of smoke, metal, and blood. Men in battered armour sharpened their swords and tended to their mounts. Each saluted or bowed as he passed, their chainmail glinting in the dim light. He felt their determination but saw the weariness in their eyes, nodding back to each of them. His gwelhir elven scout, a silent presence closely behind. The tents and supplies were so packed he struggled to find passageways.

I'll have to lead the damned horse if it gets any more crowded. That would be a fine sight, wouldn't it, Begrim? Would have made your mother proud, he thought to himself with a grim expression as he made his way forward towards the council's tent on the eastern side of the camp. Finally dismounting, his boots sank into the mud. He patted his black stallion's neck, offering a silent thank you for the hard ride that brought him here, before making his way toward his advisors' tent.

The chatter of heated debate reached Begrim's ears well before he arrived at the tent. He hated the inevitable bickering these meetings led to, but he hurried towards the tent. The winds in Ilskar cut right to the bone, and he preferred to be out of the cold sooner rather than later. Flickering torchlight cast restless shadows onto the fabric walls, offering a silhouette of the animated conversation within. A guard outside saluted, then flung the tent flap open, announcing, "High King Begrim Whitmore of Erahnia!"

Inside were dignitaries from three corners of his kingdom. The Lord marshal, an imposing figure from the barren north of Ilskar, was broad shouldered and unyielding. Their spiritual leader, from the land of Kheld, wore garments of a unique teal hue. The light of the torches reflected from

her striking blue eyes. Lastly, the slender scout from Gwelhir, was impossible to miss — a towering wood elf with sharply pointed ears and a cascade of orange hair that flowed down to his waist.

A hush fell upon the room.

Bowed heads, and a chorus of unified whispers greeted him: “My king.” Acknowledging them with a raised hand, he skipped individual pleasantries; there were urgent matters to discuss.

Seating himself on a modest wooden throne at the far end of the tent, he got straight to the point. “I thought we sent the army to protect the border from raiding parties? The men outside look like they've seen far more than that. I need the latest reports. Now.”

The Lord Marshal was the first to break the silence, his voice slicing through the thick tension like a blade. “My king, your sons have led the forces here well, but the reported attacks were larger than our initial estimates. Our forces met fierce resistance. It seems the Elgerekt are amassing in force for another assault. They are killing and looting in their wake. No attempts have been made for diplomacy. Their purpose, it seems, is solely to destroy.”

The ranger stepped forward, “Our scouts have tried to approach their borders, but the Elgerekt have heavily fortified them. The paths we once used to meet with them have been closed off; many have died in the process. It's too risky to travel into their lands now.”

Next, the cleric came into the light. Her face was troubled. “My liege, they wield magic like nothing we've seen. It decays the lands and it brings only death. Our healers are helpless in the face of its darkness.” She paused, looking at the flaps of the tent blowing in the wind. “Whatever has twisted their minds is surely what powers that evil.”

Begrim listened, gritting his teeth more with each report. At last, he stood, and paced as he processed the news. He paused, inhaling sharply. "My mother orchestrated the largest military

alliance in our continent's history. After enjoying nearly sixty years of peace. We're now under attack from the Elgerekt? These peaceful nomads are corrupted by death magic?"

He paused, sinking back into his throne, his forehead resting in his palm.

And you promised I would be the first king to rule in peace, mother, the thought nearly made him laugh in despair.

He carried on, “Lord Marshal,” he stared at the towering figure, “Elgerekt has never involved itself in our conflicts or shown interest in our politics. Yet, I trust we have kept an eye on their military capabilities. For precaution, if nothing else.”

The Marshal opened his mouth as if to protest, but stopped himself and then his gaze moved from the king to the ranger.

The elf answered, nodding, "Indeed, my liege. The Lord Marshal instructed us to monitor their military power. A safety measure, undoubtedly." The elf shot an annoyed glance towards the Marshal.

Begrim shook his head slowly, mulling over the information. "Then, tell me," he continued, "do the Elgerekt, death magic or not, stand any chance against us in war?”

The Marshal, this time, answered firmly, having regained his composure. “Not a chance, my king. Our weaponry is superior, and our numbers are fivefold theirs.”

Before Begrim could respond, he heard bells clanging and a commotion erupted at the tent flap. The council fell silent, turning as one to the disturbance.

A guard stuck his head through, “My liege, the alarm is sounding. What are your orders?”

Begrim set his jaw, “Lord Marshal, ready the troops, the rest of us remain here to wait for a report, we must know what is happening before we act. Go with Lumaire’s light.” The Lord Marshal saluted and left with hurried steps.

Before long two guards burst in the tent, faces grim, hauling a wounded scout between them, his uniform dark with blood, his body limp.

Begrim felt a cold dread as he took in the scout's dire state. The soldiers laid their burden before the council, the scout's eyes found the king's. With a struggle that etched deeper lines of pain across his features, the scout delivered his message in a hoarse, barely audible whisper. “They are here.”

Those chilling words sparked an immediate flurry of activity from the council. And as Begrim hurried out of the tent he could swear the alarm bells clanged more ominously somehow. As the other leaders dashed to their respective stations, Begrim donned his armour and rallied his honour guard.

The army had assembled swiftly, as Begrim and his entourage made their way out of the camp, the men were already forming ranks, archers, cavalry and footmen in neat formations before the enemy host could break through the edge of the forest on the opposing side of the field. From the forest's edge, the fearsome figures of Elgerekt soldiers emerged, their tall, bearded figures an imposing sight. They wore battered leather armour, in contrast to the Capital's polished chain mail and finely-woven uniforms. Each held dual battle axes or a single axe paired with a shield.

The king stood before his assembled troops, his eyes surveying the sea of faces in front of him, faces etched with a complex blend of fear, determination, and hope. He closed his eyes and steeled himself, then drawing his sword and holding it high he cried, “Soldiers of the Isle, today we stand at a precipice. It’s not just our survival that hangs in the balance, but the very essence of the

peace our ancestors fought so hard for. Let them hear the thunder of our unity; let them feel the tremors of our resolve. For our homes, our kin, and everything we hold dear!”

As his words reverberated through the air, his men cheered, chants rose as those closest to the king relayed the words to those further away. Begrim's keen eyes noticed strange figures emerging from the Elgerekt lines. Hooded figures, their visages obscured, directed the troops. They were surrounded by heavily armoured warriors, their armour darker and more ominous than anything he had seen before.

He watched the enemy approach, his heart pounding, then he caught a glimpse of his two sons shouting orders from their mounts. They were tall in their saddles, and he was proud.

But there was no time for sentiment. Tightening his grip on the hilt of his sword, he took a deep breath and gave the order. His voice rose above the ambient sounds of a battlefield on the brink. “Charge!”

For a heartbeat, there was close to silence, a collective inhalation of a thousand breaths. Then, with a thunderous roar, they surged forward. The ground shuddered under the blows of a thousand hooves, a rumbling drumbeat that echoed in his bones. He felt the raw power of the horse beneath him, muscles straining and heart pounding in a wild rhythm that matched his own. The wind whipped at his face, mingling with the acrid stench of sweat and fear. Ahead, the enemy line loomed closer, a wall of steel and darkness.

Each stride closing distance with a terrifying inevitability. His heart hammered against his ribs, every beat a countdown to impact.

He could see the whites of the enemy's eyes now, and the lack of fear in them made him feel it all the more. Time seemed to stretch, every second a drawn-out eternity. He could hear his own breathing, harsh and ragged, blending with the thunder of hooves and the growing cacophony of war cries.

They collided. Steel sang against steel, drowning out cries in a symphony of violence. Horses, crazed and riderless, ran amok, painting the field with red streaks. Begrim tried to keep his bearings in the chaos. He saw a lieutenant take an axe in his back and die. Then, he noticed the grass beneath his horse wither as one of the hooded figures chanted, palm to the cold earth. He fell from the saddle as his horse reared. He tasted dirt upon hitting the ground, and the world spun.

As he regained his vision, he saw a hooded figure stabbing the already fallen officer, and he felt the hair on his neck stand as the clearly dead soldier rose, eyes glowing like blue flames. But he had no time to question it further; someone was approaching — a nightmare made of black iron. He thought he could see a woman's face under the visor, but she had those same demonic blue eyes. Begrim hauled himself up, his movements sluggish, as he readied himself to defend. Blade clashed against blade, each clang a desperate prayer, each parry a defiance. His strength ebbed with each blow.

The cut was sudden, a searing slash of pain that tore through his flesh. His skin burned where the blade had sliced, and blood began to trickle, hot and sticky. The creature left him to his fate as he fell, the world blurring around him. He could smell the dirt he lay upon — damp, earthy, and laced with the scent of decaying grass. Each ragged breath filled his nostrils with the pungent aroma, grounding him in his agony. Sound escaped him, replaced by a high-pitched ringing, and in the distance, something swam into view — his sons, screaming. Behind them, the Lord Marshal pleaded. *Fools, listen to the man! Retreat, it is lost.* As his eyes slowly closed, the sharp pain

dulled, replaced by a numbing cold. He thought of their voices, feeling an overwhelming tiredness that tugged at his consciousness, pulling him towards the darkness.

*** Shift in character perspective

Chapter 1

A Requiem for the Forgotten

They were winning, Ghalen's mad gamble had paid off, the enemy had only brought half of their forces. He saw the destruction in the fields — so much death, not even nature had tried to reclaim it. It was hard to believe that only three years ago, the very best of the Isle's forces had fallen here, and his father with them. He clenched his fist harder around the hilt of his blade. "Press the attack!"

The enemy was in shambles now. A few of the remaining war beasts fell to arrows or spears. The towering axe wielders fought to the last, but only one of those dreadful death generals remained, along with its dark puppet master. As they pressed on, Ghalen could see an opening in the enemy lines, a straight path to the hooded figure. He looked to his side. "Haldor!" Of course, Haldor had also seen it. Nothing went past the man.

He nodded back at Ghalen's command and sprang through the opening, his blade coming down like lightning on the enemy leader. Ghalen could catch the shock from under the man's hood as Haldor's blade split his chest open.

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A loud bang woke her. *What is happening? Where am I?* As her eyes adjusted to the light, the world revealed itself in a haze of agony and confusion. A battlefield littered with the fallen, their banners unknown to her. She tried to recall her name, her purpose, but the more she tried, the more these things eluded her.

In her mind, there was only one image: a hooded figure shrouded in shadow, raising a black blade. Then, unimaginable pain shot through her body, followed by nothingness.

She rose on shaky legs, surveying the shattered remnants of war. Dust and smoke turned the landscape into a ghostly scene, through which she could make out the remnants of loss. Trees, once towering and majestic, now stood mutilated. Fragile tufts of grass hinted at the vibrant life this wasteland once nurtured.

The field before her held splintered weapons and discarded armour. The thick smell of blood was mixed with the earthy scent of rain-soaked mud. Three figures before her: warriors clad in crude leather armour, their hands gripping battle axes beside a fallen, wolf-like creature. Were they friends or foes? She searched their faces for any sign of recognition, but all she found was shocked features.

A battle cry pierced the air, catching her off guard. Before she fully grasped the situation, the warriors charged. Her body responded instinctively.

She sidestepped an oncoming blade, grasped the assailant's arm, and used his momentum to hurl him to the ground. The world around her blurred and she was drawn to a gleaming blade nearby. She seized it and plunged it deep into an approaching soldier.

Every parry, every dodge and counterattack, felt innate, as if she had performed this dance thousands of times before — a forgotten memory resurfacing. And in just a few moments, a trail of fallen enemies lay in testament to her power.

"Look! They are fighting amongst themselves," a distant voice cried out, barely audible over the chaos of battle.

More enemies? she wondered, gripping the hilt of her blade tighter. But as she scanned for these newcomers, she noticed they were draped in neatly tailored tunics of teal cloth layered over chainmail — clearly a different faction, and by their defensive formation, an organised one. Her attention quickly shifted from their shouts as robed figures emerged behind the soldiers and began to encircle her.

They extracted small, carved stones from their pouches, the symbols on them faintly glowing. Poised to attack, she watched as they tossed the stones around her. The figures started chanting, their hands clasped as if in prayer, and the carvings on the stones began to emit a soft glow. She found herself unable to move; the more she struggled, the more difficult it became. Gritting her teeth, she hissed, “Release me…” Her eyelids grew heavy, and with a blink, “You demons…” She tried to say, but what emerged was barely a whisper as she once again succumbed to the enveloping darkness.

A dull throb in her temples dragged her from sleep, she was bound and battered, in what appeared to be a tent used as a temporary armoury. Despite her aching body, she tried to get her bearings, looking for anything that might aid her situation. In the corner of the tent, she noticed a set of black plate armour, distinct from both the leather worn by her attackers and the chainmail of her captors. *Did I wear that?* she wondered, squinting.

Through the commotion outside, she strained her ears, catching snippets of a conversation between the guards stationed outside. By the tone of their voices, they were confused.

“By Lumaire’s light, We killed the Dark Master. Why is she not dead?” one guard said, a hint of fear in his voice. "A bad omen, I'm sure,"

A second guard weighed in, “The Westfolk feared her as much as we did. And she was killing her own before we cornered her. But I don’t see why he ordered us to capture her.”

Their conversation ceased, replaced by a palpable tension. Someone was approaching. She tensed, her body was prepared to react, even if her mind did not know what to do.

The entrance to the tent was flung open, revealing an imposing silhouette against the backdrop of the setting sun. As her eyes adjusted to the light, she studied the man who entered. His youth seemed marred by battles, tanned skin scarred and bruised, hand resting on his sword hilt. Black hair, like charcoal and neatly tied back, framed a pair of intense brown eyes. His armour, similar to that of his guards but adorned with gold embellishments, bore the crest of a mountain chain — a sign of high rank, she guessed. The large, calloused hands, especially the right one marked by a prominent scar across its back, testified to a man who did not shy away from battle. She thought she detected a tremble in his scarred hand. *A scared youth at the front of an army?* she wondered with a frown.

His gaze filled with awe or perhaps fear, as if he were confronted with a mythical beast brought to life. She felt a prickle of unease, a flicker of vulnerability. *Am I a beast?*

“I am Ghalen Whitmore, commander of these forces.” His voice carried an authority that belied his youthful appearance. “I believe you've lost your memories,” he remarked, his words echoing through the tent. A weighted pause lingered, expecting some form of acknowledgment, but she remained silent, lost in the maze of her thoughts. “You were fighting alongside the Western Elgerekt. Does that trigger any memories?”

How does he know I lost my memories? The commander's words faded into the background, as foreign to her as an unfamiliar tongue. She tried to make sense of everything, fragments popped into her mind; they had questioned her earlier when they removed her armour, they had not been gentle then.

Whitmore spoke of war, puppeteers of the dead, and her role as a formidable general, she felt more lost than ever.

A surge of panic rose as she remembered the hooded figure stabbing her, *The wound in my chest? Did they patch it?* She could not see any bleeding, and the only pain she felt was from the guards earlier. Yet her hands were bound behind her back so she could not touch her chest. They had to have patched it, that wound would have killed her, and she was alive, *I am alive… right?*

The commander continued to pace the room, muttering to himself or perhaps to her "Perhaps a woodland elf?" he speculated, his eyes tracing her face. His expression quickly shifted to one of doubt, and he shook his head, as if dismissing the possibility.

She turned to the side, catching her reflection in the polished shield by the wall. Her ears: long and pointed, almost twisting like ram horns. Skin pale, intricate markings under her eyes and Her brown hair hung in tangled strands, streaked with dirt. The flower-shaped jewel woven into her hair felt familiar somehow.

"Could you be...a high elf?" he asked, lowering his voice to a hushed whisper. It was as though speaking too loud might dispel an illusion. "Could you be from beyond the great Elven Wall?"

Her heart fluttered at his words, an echo of familiarity ringing in her ears. The mention of the wall stirred something within her, like a half-remembered dream.

She had no answers. For the first time since waking up in the battle field, fear gripped her. She did not know her identity or nature. The men around her viewed her as a mythical creature. And she somehow knew myths usually stirred fear and led to tragic ends. Despair filled her.

“No matter,” Ghalen sighed. “When our great warriors fall, the enemy raises them to fight against us. But if we bring down their masters, their warriors die with them. But not you. You still stand and even fought against them.” He gave her a stern look. “There is a prophecy in our church that an angel of Lumaire would take the form of a high elf and deliver us. I’ve never put much faith in prophecy, but you look like no creature I have ever seen. If we were to show you mercy, perhaps your kind could help our cause.”

He wants me to end this war? I don’t even know who I am. Ghalen's eyes locked onto hers, searching, questioning.

His stare was intense. “Do you truly not remember anything of your past?” he asked, a hint of desperation lurking behind that steady gaze.

She hesitated, feeling exposed. “I told your people, I don’t know who I am, or where I come from. Besides, why should I trust you?”

He grunted, “Do you have any other option?”

Death, she thought, and with a sigh she added “When you mentioned the Elven Wall... It felt familiar, like something I once knew.”

His gaze softened for a moment. “Very well,” he added. “Our path home to the capital will lead us past the great gate. Humans normally steer clear from it, it is… unpleasant for the mind. Perhaps what bothers us could help spark something in your memory. Or time might bring something back to you. However,” he added, crossing his arms, “we cannot trust you. Restraints will be necessary.”

Before she could respond, a guard stepped up, raising his voice. “Ghalen, Are you truly inviting this... demon to join us? The journey home is already dangerous without an enemy in our midst!”

Ghalen raised his hand. “Khain, my decisions are not made lightly. Do not doubt my judgement, banner general.”

The man's voice wavered, “No, sire, but she fought against us. I fear for—”

“Enough” Ghalen interjected. “Fear has two sides: the known and the unknown. Maybe, by knowing her better, we might find an ally where once we saw an enemy. Besides, do you think one disarmed, bound woman will defeat what remains of our company?”

Khain bowed his head. “I overstepped.” He left the tent in a hurry.

Outside she heard muffled voices, one whispering, “Has the boy lost his mind?”

Another voice shushed the first, “Be careful with your words. Do not question His orders so boldly. He could have your tongue for that.”

She thought her hearing might be sharp, because if Ghalen picked up on the exchange, he showed no sign of it.

He turned back to her, extending his hand. “So, will you come along nicely?”

She looked into his eyes, “what if I did not?”

“I don’t want more bloodshed.”

“But you can’t let me go?”

“No, I cannot.” He frowned.

Better a prisoner than dead I suppose, “I’ll play along, if that will keep my head on my shoulders.” *Can I help end this war? Or will I make it worse?* she thought, staring at the ground.

As she agreed, Ghalen gave a sigh of relief. “The journey back to the east will be a test of endurance and patience. We are still within contested territory, with several days of arduous riding ahead. The enemy forces are scattered across these lands, and passage will not be easily granted.”

The two guards stationed outside entered as Ghalen left. They hauled her to her feet and led her outside. Dirty, tired faces stared back at her. What remained of the victorious band seemed to be a force of less than a hundred strong. She saw frowns and narrowed eyes as she was led past them, but she steeled herself, ready to face the challenges that lay ahead.

The guards stowed her in an open carriage, her wrists and ankles bound, and her body draped in a green cloak to shield her from the harsh winds. They outfitted her in the teal robes of their healers, woven with brass detailing, very different from the intimidating plate armour she had worn in battle. The looming darkness mimicked her current state of mind — shrouded and uncertain. Around her, the men and women of the company prepared for travel, their movements efficient and sure, completely opposite to the turmoil within her.

She remained preoccupied with the haunting memory of the hooded figure and the searing pain that had consumed her. She closed her eyes, searching her body for any remnants of the wound. But there was nothing. No scar, no lingering ache. It was as if the memory existed in a realm separate from her physical being. A shiver ran down her spine, a disturbing realisation that she had defied death itself, emerging from the abyss untouched. She thought about coming face to face with the Great Wall which brought a strange feeling of calmness. Her gaze settled on the distant battlefield where she had been captured. Despite the horror of the scene, her eyes lingered on the field, her shoulders slumping ever so slightly. She swallowed hard. It was the only thing she knew in this strange world.

Her captors' fallen comrades were retrieved and buried with ceremony, while the leather-clad warriors became a feast for crows, an exception was made for the hooded figures which were burned. There was much movement, packing and saddling of horses, loading of carriages. Weapons were cleaned and packed, soldiers patched each other's wounds, and those more gravely wounded were helped by cloaked figures whose faces she could only see in passing.

For some reason carts set off with just a couple of riders in different directions without any cargo, but with many riderless horses in tow.

A soldier with a large build mounted the front of her cart grabbing the reins, he turned to face her. She expected a vicious glance and a snarky comment, but his smile was warm, “The name’s Pieor Orlek, Ghalen's personal guard.” He adjusted the reins. “Riding with him, I reckon we'll be crossing paths quite a bit, Mistress.” he turned as Ghalen approached and gave him a respectful nod.

Ghalen, mounted the carriage, “Everything's ready. Our enemy should struggle to track us. Let's go.”

They left the mangled battlefield behind. The war-tainted air gave way to the freshness of untouched nature, a balm to her soul. Gradually, she surrendered to the lulling motion of the cart, dozing off to the rhythmic sound of the horses' hooves against the earth. Her mind wavered in visions of war, destruction, and always the hooded figure looming over her, but there was something new, she thought she could make out a figure in a garden, watching over a rose at its centre, it was withering.

When she came to, the sun was no longer in the sky. Hushed voices spoke at the head barely audible over the rumble of the carriage. Pieor, driving the cart, was speaking fast in a speculative conversation with Ghalen.

“Could she really be a high elf like the stories?” Pieor's voice quivered with doubt. “Not very good with books or history, but did they not all leave thousands of years ago? Maybe she is just an odd looking Gwelhir elf?”

“Why don't you ask her yourself?” Ghalen countered. Throwing a glance backwards.

Turning around with an embarrassed blush on his cheeks, Pieor quickly apologised.

“Can you tell me about these Gwelhir elves? Do they look like me?” *From what I saw in that shield I look nothing like these people.*

Pieor scratched his chin. “Well,” he said, “the elves of Gwelhir live much longer than us humans, that's for sure. And from what I've seen, their hair is always orange, like fire itself. Their ears are much longer too, though not quite as long as yours, I reckon. My old nan always said, 'the longer the ears, the longer they live.'”

“Nonsense,” Ghalen interrupted. “Elves' ears have nothing to do with their lifespan. It's said the woodland elves are descendants of the high elves, who intermingled with ancient humans. And over time, they strayed from their customs and gradually lost all resemblance to their elven kin. Where the high elves were said to live forever, their woodland relatives would live for a few hundred years.”

Pieor quickly resumed, unaffected by his commander's corrections. “That may be, but you're different," he remarked, pointing at her, “your hair is brown. And the markings on your face – elves are born with them. But woodland elves sport green markings, yours are as blue as the summer sky!”

“And would my looks make me more similar to these high elves you speak of?” she asked.

Pieor looked at her with his mouth open.

He appeared relieved when Ghalen answered, “We could not say, the gates to the supposed high elves have been closed for thousands of years, and the elves of those lands are nothing but legends to us. Our priests worship remnants of what they left behind.”

She sat in silence for a long while, listening to them talk, the conversation had changed to what routes would best avoid the wind. Pondering what was said earlier, she had no memory of anything but her seeming death, but she did not trust these men enough to share that memory.

As the carriage trundled forward, the wind was a constant companion. She saw the land transform from war torn muddy fields to new terrain. It was not welcoming; but a harsh landscape with trees sparse and leafless, even though tree buds spoke of it being springtime. Abandoned farms and desolate fields told stories of more prosperous times gone by.

Soldiers of varying ranks and attire passed them, each offering a respectful nod to Ghalen. Pieor was the only one not giving her suspicious stares; he even engaged her in conversation, he talked of a daughter and pointed to landmarks. Their exchanges provided a welcome distraction, keeping her troubled thoughts at bay. Her captors did not seem all that bad, this Pieor seemed quite kind to her.

When the sun reached high in the sky, casting a warm light that hinted at the summer to come, four distinct riders appeared. The teal of their hoods resembled the one she wore, adorned with intricate bronze jewellery. The riders felt familiar. Were they the same figures who had ensnared her with their magic on the battlefield? Their hoods were pulled back now, revealing beautiful, ice-blue eyes set against bronze faces framed by raven-black hair dripping with jewels. Their regal bearing was evident, even in their saddles.

They offered the customary nod to Ghalen, but they seemed to look right through Pieor. The elf sensed an undercurrent of tension. Other soldiers' passed the four riders with suspicious glances, moving out of their way as if to avoid a bad smell.

As they got out of earshot she turned to Pieor, “Who are they? And why do they seem so...unwelcome among the soldiers?”

Pieor sighed deeply, scratching his moustache. “Them? They're the Kheld, from the far south. Priests and priestesses of the Church of Lumaire in the capital. They're usually engrossed in their books and they know some healing arts. In most places across the Isle, they’re revered,” he muttered.

Not able to catch everything else he said, she thought she heard something like, ‘They should be grateful one of the tower seats rides with us. But this is Ilskar. People say books don't fend off wolves or bring in the harvest. I've learned a few things since moving to the capital, in no small part thanks to Ghalen, but people here are sceptical of what they don't understand. Funny how quickly that changes when they’re injured,’ he added, a note of amusement flavouring his voice.

She furrowed her brow, glancing at the vibrant display of flags surrounding them. Each one had a distinct emblem and a colour scheme that seemed to hold meaning. “What's with all the flags, Pieor?”

He followed her gaze. “District banners. Erahnia's a big place, you know. Twelve districts, each with its own lord and a spiffy flag to show for it.”

She nodded. “And under which banner do you serve?”

He pointed to a teal banner with three mountains in its centre “The capital of Highfarra. All other banners defer to it. It answers to the Lord Marshal himself.”

“Lord Marshal? Have I seen him?”

“No, he’s not here. Most men under our banner are busy at other fronts….” he trailed off.

She surveyed the scene, counting five distinct colours among the flags.

This Pieor appeared to be a talkative man, something she did not mind as he seemed indulged to teach her. He talked until the sun was setting and the cold kicked in. A scout returned with suggestions for a campsite, reporting an enclave some fifteen minutes' ride away. She tried her best to huddle deeper into her cloak, fighting the encroaching cold, *a fire would be nice,* she thought.

Chapter 2

Calm of the night

Stars gleamed in the sky as the caravan made their makeshift camp, nestled in the heart of the enclave. The wind was not as harsh in the deep of the woods, leaving a peaceful hush over the company. Her body was exhausted after bumping around the cart like a sack of grain on the harsh roads. Around her, soldiers moved slowly, their shoulders slumped and steps dragging. Some sank

to the ground with groans, while others leaned heavily on their weapons, eyes glazed and unfocused.

A coolness seeped into the air, wrapping them in a chilling embrace, creeping through her garb, settling into her bones. With each breath she released, a puff of vapour appeared before her, a ghostly spectre dissolving into the frigid night. She shifted, trying to adjust her breathing to come slower in this unfamiliar, frosty atmosphere.

Moonlight reflected in the few patches of wet grass, washing the camp in an ethereal glow that softened the harsh lines of fatigue on the faces of those around her. It was a serene scene.

Whispers of the wind caressed the leaves, setting them into a soft, rhythmic rustle. Scrambling noises suggested the presence of unseen critters of the forest going about their nocturnal life. She closed her eyes, allowing her mind to picture these tiny creatures, and found herself dreaming she was running free in that garden of roses from her vision.

The quiet of the night shattered as a howl reverberated, leaving an echo that made her skin prickle with unease. Soldiers traded uneasy glances.

One soldier's fingers twitched over his sword's hilt, his eyes darting across the shadowy forest perimeter. “Wolves this far east?”

“They fought with beasts, but I thought Ghalen had our tracks well-concealed.” Another added swallowing hard.

Ghalen’s voice cut through the tension, “Double the guard and keep your weapons ready, there is no need to fear an enemy that is not yet here. Still, we would be fools not to prepare for one who might come.” he added, a subtle edge of worry colouring his voice.

His soldiers nodded solemnly.

As they carefully unpacked and began setting sharpened stakes towards the edge of camp, the tension was palpable in the air. Afraid, clearing her throat, she caught Ghalen's attention through the soldiers' quiet labour. "Perhaps you could unbind my arms," she suggested, her eyes going back and forth between the soldiers and Ghalen. The confidence that her body had innately on the battlefield was leaving her by the minute, and she longed to hold a blade again, somehow it had made her calm when she grabbed it. "I may be able to help protect us if something were to happen."

The words, a single pebble tossed into the vast, still pond of the night.

The men stared at her with blank expressions. They had witnessed her martial prowess on the battlefield, but she had been their enemy. Her skills, impressive as they were, had been directed against them and felled many of their comrades.

Ghalen retorted, his voice resonant in the quiet. "Do not mistake our courtesy for trust. We witnessed your martial prowess on the battlefield, but it was as our enemy. We will not hand you a weapon unless circumstances leave us no other choice."

As he turned from her, she could see guards nodding to each other in agreement. Her attention returned to the forest's edge, senses heightened. *Was the howl just a random cry? Or was it the cry of enemies that are drawing ever closer?*

Two of Ghalen's handpicked guards settled close to her — one familiar from their travels, the other a stranger. Both towering figures, the strangers' expression emotive as a stone. Each of them appeared strong enough to break a man in half. Their purpose was clear: to ensure she remained harmless.

Pieor, his thick brown moustache working as he spoke, loomed large by the fire. A towering presence which eclipsed any other man she had seen in the band. Every so often, he'd add a log to

the fire, the muscles in his arms flexing as he reached for them. And the other man introduced himself as Haldor, less towering, but no less imposing. His face, with a neatly trimmed stubble, showed meticulous grooming, much unlike the weary and battle-worn faces around. It seemed in this dire situation, he still clung to the threads of discipline.

Pieor scooted closer to the fire. “We're not jailers, Mistress. We're here by King Ghalen’s decree, purely for safety,” his rough voice tinged with a hint of discomfort.

Beside him, Haldor shifted in his seat, sitting up straighter. “It's a necessary precaution,” he asserted.

The contrast in their voices captured her attention — Haldor's refined, almost courtly manner against Pieor's coarser, more rustic speech, which was closer to other soldiers she had met.

“Uneasy night, isn't it?” Pieor muttered, scratching his moustache. “Especially with that forest lurking out there. Seems the shadows are thicker than usual tonight.”

Haldor nodded in response. “I don’t disagree.”

As the two guards continued their small talk, her gaze kept drifting back to the edge of the forest. The darkness beyond seemed sentient, glaring back at her. She clenched her fists, a silent scream of frustration swelling within her at her helplessness.

She could not make out what the two were saying over the mix of fear and jumbled thoughts in her head. One memory bubbled up above the rest, *what had Pieor called Ghalen?* And she blurted it out, “The boy is a king?” Her mouth tightened, she had not meant to speak it aloud.

Both men paused, exchanging surprised looks.

Pieor responded, “He may seem young, Mistress, but don’t let that fool you. He’s a good leader.”

Haldor’s only reply was a grunt; His expression never changed.

Pieor glanced at Haldor then sighed, “Ghalen was meant for books, not swords. But Life had other plans for him. His grandmother, Lady Ironhand, tough as nails she was, created a peace that lasted for years. But sadly, we do not get to enjoy it. Now, Ghalen is the last heir of the Whitmore line.”

As Pieor's tales of the King unfolded, her shoulders dropped, leaning back, her hands now rested on her lap. She felt at ease here around the fire with soldiers around her.

Pieor’s eyes softened, “In time, perhaps you'll come to understand him. Beneath that exterior is a courage that's rare.”

He added with a fond smile, “He is sharper than any other tactician, not one man on the Isle could beat him in a game of Isle Dominion that’s for sure.”

The fire crackled, punctuating the silence. “As we've sworn to the king, no harm will come to you, Mistress.” Pieor vowed with renewed seriousness.

As their conversation grew more casual, she grinned playfully. “Why do you keep calling me 'Mistress?”

Pieor laughed heartily, “look at you! With your sparkling green eyes and that golden thing in your hair, it seems fitting.”

Haldor, expressionless, added, “It suits your demeanour perfectly.”

As the night unfurled, the forest sank into a profound silence that seemed unnatural. Fog was rolling in over the hills and creeping close to the forest. She saw a guard squinting through the gloom, “I swear I saw—” He rubbed his tired eyes.

“Surely just your imagination, an afterimage from the flames.” Another added.

As the first man turned towards his comrade a wolf lept from the darkness, its jaws clasped the man's throat, the quiet of the night was instantly shattered. The forest came alive with the savage cries of wild beasts, their movements uncannily coordinated

“Wolves!” The men shouted throughout the camp. “Take arms!”

Screams and curses ripped through the night as the men were yanked from sleep. Hands scrambled for weapons, eyes wide with terror and grim resolve. Whirling swords cast long, silver arcs in the moonlight. Battle cries, raw and desperate, mingled with the guttural roars of their attackers.

Amidst the clash and clamour, she could see other figures materialise — wraiths from the encroaching darkness, Their features covered by black hoods. They moved with an unsettling grace, silent and swift, daggers glinting in their hands as they struck with chilling precision.

Bound and helpless, she could do nothing but watch the unfolding carnage. Her heart pounded in her chest, her breaths short and quick, as a beast detached itself from the battle and stalked towards her, eyes glowing red in the dim light. She made out a wolf, but three times the size it should be. Its low growl rumbled like a distant storm. Closer and closer it came. Pedalling backwards as much as her bound legs would allow, she ended up against a tree, paralyzed by fear. She stared at it and waited for the inevitable.

Just as the beast lunged, Pieor came into view, rushing forward sword drawn. His blade flashing in a wide arc, distracting the beast. Haldor was right behind him, plunging his sword deep into the beast's side. The creature howled, turning to retaliate, but Haldor twisted his sword, causing the beast to snarl, the sound soon turned into a whimper and then silence. As the beast crumpled to the ground, The two soldiers stood their ground, eyes scanning the battlefield.

In the heart of this mayhem, she saw Ghalen fighting valiantly, his rallying cries igniting courage in his men. Blades clashed with teeth and claws, bodies fell, but his guards' did not relent.

A shadowy figure darted towards the king. Before anyone could react, a glint of metal flashed, and a choked gasp escaped Ghalen's lips as a blade found its mark through his armour.

With a roar, a captain cut the assassin down, but the damage was done.

As her eyes went from Ghalen to the rest of the soldiers she could tell the enemy was finished, the last few cornered or dead and an eerie hush descended as the last clang of steel faded. No triumphant roars, no celebratory cries, just a suffocating silence that pressed down on the battlefield.

As her own horror settled, she saw Ghalen crumpled, unmoving. *I can help,* she thought. Her mouth felt dry. It wasn't supposed to be this way. The king. He lay sprawled nearby, breaths coming in ragged gasps. The vibrant night sky, once a calming backdrop, now mocked them with its indifferent twinkle.

The silence of the night reclaimed the battlefield with the exception of moans from the wounded, the dying king called his men to his side, his voice strained with pain. “Crown my cousin,” he gasped, his features etched with agony. “He will... lead you in the final battle.”

She had been a mere observer, bound and helpless. Now, she felt an overwhelming urge to do something, to ease the suffering around her even if she did not know how. “Unbind me, I can help,” she demanded, her voice resonating with a determination that made the men glance at each other.

“What can that demon do for us?” Khain spat out the words, those around him nodding in agreement.

Pieor stepped up to him, towering over the general. “Lumaire's light, there is no demon inside her, she says she can help!” He growled and the nods stopped.

“But, she is our—”

Haldor cut her bonds, “it can hardly get worse.”

No sooner had the ropes fallen from her wrists and ankles, a potent unseen force pulled her to the wounded king. Compelled by some instinct, she placed her hand over his gory wound. *Heal him, heal him, I have to heal him ,but how?*

Ethereal glow spread around her, illuminating the darkened camp as if a lantern had been lit amongst them. She felt a soothing warmth, and as she looked up soldiers relaxed, shoulders dropped and nobody shuddered from the cold any longer. Confusion was still written on their faces and many still had their blades pointed at her. Before their eyes, the king's grievous wounds began to mend, his skin knitting together under her touch.

The warm light gradually dissipated, leaving them in silence.

“She healed him!” Somebody cried out. They gasped and somebody cheered.

Then she felt a cramp in her stomach and collapsed in a scream of pain. The exertion of the mysterious power left her writhing in agony, and then it all went black.